International tourism and globalization have certainly brought about changes. The walls of the hotel where I'm staying are adorned with backpacker-chic images of Che Guevara and Bob Marley. On the roof deck, they play the kind of music I can only call 'Western yoga pop'. I'm tickled to see a cannabis shoot growing in a plant pot. The hotel's young owner and manager, a local man of Thakur descent, met a young Russian tourist seven years ago and married her the previous year. He says with a chuckle that his family went along on the condition that they never get divorced. Both now live in town but spend their summers in Russia. He tells me that his sister's recent marriage set him back by Rs 35 lakh (US $55K), the majority of it being dowry; he disapproves of dowry but yielded after recognizing its entrenched reality in his orthodox Thakur community. He's surprised when I tell him that had they lived in Chandela times, his family may well have received a bride price instead.

The state of Madhya Pradesh has tried to revive some traditions with the annual week-long Khajuraho Dance Festival, whose forty-fourth edition falls during my visit. It is inaugurated by Anandiben Patel, the state governor and former chief minister of Gujarat. Her entourage mercifully arrives only an hour late. The audience waits under a darkening sky, resenting this display of self-importance that seems to me more befitting a Chandela king. Another evening I attend a *Hasya Kavi Sammelan* ('comic poets conference'), which uses both 'standard' and Bundelkhandi Hindi, the latter of which I often miss. Listening to them I wonder about the Chandela sense of humour. Would they have laughed at these jokes?

The Roots of Erotica in Religious Art

The basic idea of fusing sexual and religious imagery has appeared in many parts of the world. Folk religions often evoke new life and rejuvenation through magico-religious symbols and acts. In India, the earliest such surviving imagery dates from the Harappan times, such as the phallic statues of Dholavira.[20] The Mauryan period has turned up many small terracotta plaques, likely used as votive offerings to popular fertility goddesses like Sri. These plaques have symbolic—non-erotic and non-amorous—depictions of male–female unions, believed to be auspicious for